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THE NEW *AICONS* OF BOLLYWOOD

Artificial intelligence is making its presence felt in the creative realm of Indian cinema. The fraternity remains divided on its potential, with one side viewing it as a creative force, the other side as a disruptive one

By ***SUHANI SINGH***

Shakun Batra, writer-director of the emotionally charged *Kapoor & Sons* and *Gehraiyaan*, is not the kind of filmmaker you'd expect to deliver riveting car chases. "People see me as an emotional, personal-dynamics filmmaker, so nobody would give me the money to do one [an action sequence]," he says, seated in Dharma Entertainment's office. But after experimenting with artificial intelligence [AI] tools like ChatGPT, Sora and Google Veo, Batra has done exactly that, conjured his first high-octane short, *The Getaway Car*, and set it in Montreal. "Had I done it the traditional way, it would have required a 50-member crew, cars and permission from local government to block streets, a stunt team, security, flying in actors to Montreal and putting them up in hotels," he says. Instead, a bit of deft prompt engineering (instructing AI precisely for a desired, superior result), and Batra was able to step out of his comfort zone and explore a genre he'd never handled before.

The Getaway Car wasn't Batra's first tryst with AI. He had begun dabbling with advanced AI tools while shooting commercials. "I created an AI-powered shot, which, funnily, the client chose over the one I had actually shot on set," recalls Batra. "I didn't know if I had failed as a traditional filmmaker or succeeded on the AI front." The spark thus lit, Batra soon began sharing AI-generated teasers on Instagram. He'd eventually collaborate with Google Gemini to make *The Getaway Car*. Today, he uses ChatGPT to generate quick script synopses, character breakdowns and "even to understand the psychological dynamics of a character".


MAHABHARATA


THE GETAWAY CAR